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Ingrid Sertso

Vocalist, poet and teacher Ingrid Sertso was born in Munich, Germany on February 26, 1944. She has created adventurous music with Don Cherry, Olatunje, Ornette Coleman, and with her husband, Karl Berger. She and Karl are co-founders of the Creative Music Studio and were recently honored by the Jazz Journalists Association as "Jazz Heroes."

Ingrid was interviewed in Woodstock, New York, on August 11, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm in Woodstock, New York. I'm very pleased to be in the home of Ingrid Sertso and Karl Berger. Thank you for letting me come. And I read an interesting thing in your Columbia interview, and I thought I would try it at the front door but I didn't, and that was to ask, "Oh are there any hippies still here?" I can just picture someone, a complete stranger, "Where's the hippies?" But anyway, it's a pleasure to meet you and I've heard your name for many years, and Karl's name. And I'd like to see if I could get a handle on some of the way you create music, and you know you've been in the forefront of this music for a long time. I was thinking about the fact that jazz is about a hundred years old, give or take, and it's gone through so many styles and changes and back and forth, and getting more complex, simpler. And then I thought about the fact that Ornette Coleman did free jazz in the early sixties. How do you progress from that approach that Ornette Coleman did at that time? I don't know if you use the word "free" in what you —

IS: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Well that music was pretty free to my ears. So if that was one of the first groundbreaking recordings, where does it go from there?

IS: First of all, we have tourists coming up here that ask, roll your window down, "Is there any hippies around?" Just to answer what you asked before. Okay. Ornette invented the harmolodic approach to music and I think he helped us all to be confident in our need to really express ourselves freely. Where it goes from there, I wouldn't know. For me, Ornette is the final, at the moment. Where it would go from there, I wouldn't know. Because he is the most, that's the most natural music to me. Ornette's personal playing is very emotional, there's a lot of feeling in it, and it goes away from the whole system of the bebop, you know, of all these changes jazz went through. And before we came here it was actually Ornette that brought us. Because I'm singing much longer than Karl. I grew up in an artist family. My brother is a well-known fantastic painter, all these pictures are from him; and my mother is a classical piano player. So for me music, that was it — not

painting, music. Because my older brother was also — he brought me actually to my first jazz concert and he always painted with music, you know. He had records and it was his biggest inspiration. And then I got my own agent and I wanted to do jazz and I went into the whole standards thing. And then about three years later after I did it alone, I met Karl and then we wanted to just build something up together. He played piano in the band I worked in and then one day he came home and said, "I think I found what we need." And he brought "This is Our Music," the record of Ornette Coleman. And hearing this, we immediately went to Paris. Don Cherry was sitting in Buttercup's club. Buttercup was the wife of Bud Powell. It was shortly before Bud Powell died in Paris. And she had a club and Don Cherry was sitting there. And Karl said, "Oh, isn't that the trumpet player on the cover of 'This is Our Music'?" and he went straight over. We introduced ourselves and Karl was in the band. Me partially. Because the clubs didn't always pay a singer. So I sat in and I worked with Don as much as possible. And he brought us over here and that's how we met Ornette.

MR: So if this music that you started experimenting with was really made for personal expression — I'm not sure how to ask this question but I'll try —

IS: I'm not sure I can answer it.

MR: Can you fake an emotion?

IS: Safe?

MR: Fake it. Can you make it up?

IS: Fake.

MR: Yes. If the band —

IS: No because the music carries you. The music — if the music really comes from your complete openness in you, which is of course the heart, if it's completely open, the second you hit a note there is no way you can fake anything. Music is not really coming from us. We are just a container the music goes through, what we put our personal expression on. Because the music we are doing already existed, but not in the way we are doing it. Now if you hit a note and if you are really totally open and you hit that note, then you go with the music and there's no ego concept, there is no idea of faking, it's impossible to think, impossible. You are just with the music and you do what you had planned to do. You know? Intention, action, result.

MR: Say that again? Intention —

IS: Intention, action, result.

MR: Nice. Well did you get to a point where the words to particular songs became — weren't giving you enough or were restricting you?

IS: Oh, that's different. You are talking now about singing.

MR: Well I'm talking about singing and, you know, sometimes I almost feel sympathetic to the singers if they're singing a song — it could be a beautiful song — like for some reason on the way down here I thought about [scats] "I Can't Get Started."

IS: "I Can't Get Started."

MR: Which is a beautiful melody but the lyrics are sort of dated now. You know, "I've been around the world in a plane." So I guess what I'm trying to ask, did you get to a point with your singing in these early bands, where you gave up on the lyrics and just started.

IS: Yeah. I don't sing these songs anymore. That was when I started I had a repertoire of about 400 standards. And then we met Don, we met Ornette, then that whole free approach came, then I did a lot of improvisation without even lyrics, and now I'm supposed to make a CD for Konnex, it's a big company in Berlin, that's called "Different Standards" because they can sell it well in Japan, and I'm sorting it out. I can only sing the standards I can relate to, because they have lyrics.

MR: Can you give me a couple of examples?

IS: It will be "My Funny Valentine," "Look for the Silver Lining," I made a whole list of them. It's difficult. Because some songs have incredible melody and stupid lyrics. So if the writer of the lyrics is old enough, or is already dead for a long time, then I can change it. So I love the song "You Don't Know What Love Is" which has relative good lyrics so I'm definitely going to do that one, then "What a Wonderful World." I love the songs, and it comes out of my experience out of my studies, the songs that can relate to the whole world, can relate to people, can help people. I'm out of that whole thing, oh I have to sing this song about this band, I have to sing "Laura," I have to sing the common standards you know. So now I'm sorting out, I'm singing Jimi Hendrix songs, whom I adored you know. There must be some Bob Dylan, "There Must Be Some Kind of Way Out of Here." I sing that in my way. I have it on different CDs already. I'm going to give you one.

MR: I would love to have one.

IS: The last one I did.

MR: And being a poet, have you set any of your poems to melodies?

IS: Yes, yes. I just did "Lonely Woman" by Ornette Coleman. And Ornette never liked the lyrics. They were done by a poet he never got introduced to, by a woman. And he said, "That's not what my song is about." And Ornette and me, we just keep talking together. And so I called him and said, "Ornette, can I write some lyrics for 'Lonely Woman' and come down and show them to you and then record it? He said, "You just write it, you don't have to come down, record it and bring me the recording." Because he knows my poetry. And it's on my last CD, "Lonely Woman." And we went there, Karl and me. Ornette put it on seven times. I was so honored. Because I adore him so much. Of all the

musicians in this country, it's Ornette is like a guru to us. He's like a guru. He kept us. We wanted to leave the second week we came here. Because when you come from Europe all these musicians they come from here are superstars there. They are honored. People go to the concerts. People put extra dress on, extra suit. And then you come over here. The first experience was a very famous musician, I don't want to mention his name, a saxophone player, came over and asked Karl for a few dollars so he can buy a new mouthpiece. For us the world broke down. I went to Copacabana club because Anita O'Day was one of my favorite white singers. She sat at the bar and cried. I said to the waiter, "What's happening?" And he said, "She came late, she is fired." So it was one experience like the other and so we wanted to go back because we felt this we can't deal with. Ornette was the one that said no. He knew our music. He had already come to quite a few concerts after a few months. We immediately linked up with club managers and he came to almost every concert when he was younger. And he loved it and he said, "No, you stay in this country." He's the one that made us stay.

MR: In retrospect when you think about those times, do you have any thoughts on why this country did not recognize these people as important?

IS: No. I have no idea. I still try to figure it out. Jazz in Europe, high art. I mean we are from Europe, but jazz musicians love to go over there. They get the best hotels, there is always a room with food, wine, people are honoring them, people come for autographs. But now, if a musician from Europe wants to play here he has to pay $1500.

MR: I learned that.

IS: So now, I just went to Berlin. We did — there is this big concert for Eric Dolphy. We were one of the few people that did the last concert with him, for one night, and then he died of sugar. And Han Bennink, that famous beautiful Dutch drummer. He said, "Ingrid, I can't go to the U.S. anymore. It was my favorite trip. I can't pay $1,500."

MR: What was his name?

IS: Han Bennink.

MR: Okay.

IS: "I can't pay" — no. "I don't want to pay the $1500." He probably would be able to because he's very well known and so a little bit better off.

MR: I think we seem to value things more if they come from somewhere else.

IS: No there is no art education here. Don't forget, the reason why Europeans sometimes can be so arrogant, they have culture. Their history is lots of culture. Lots of art. There's still a fight between Germany and France. Who has the better classical musicians? Who has the better classical painters? When I met Ornette first he said, "I heard of you, you come from Europe — the best classical musicians, you should be very proud." There is no respect for art. There is no art education here. The only true art form, we found out, in

this 40 years that we are here, is jazz. Jazz could not have happened anywhere in the world. Everything is secondhand European or it comes from Asia. The American people should be so proud that jazz came from here. Because it's honored everywhere in the world but not here. I don't understand. I don't know why.

MR: Has it gotten any better? I mean we have Jazz at Lincoln Center and now almost every college, especially bigger colleges, you can go and study it.

IS: And musicians don't have to go on drugs anymore because it's better. It's a better situation. But I don't understand why it cannot be really like in Europe. Why rock & roll is so big here. I don't understand.

MR: The music that you've developed into and have been doing since then, does it require — I think this goes along with your arts education thought. Does it require something more of the audience to listen to?

IS: Yeah.

MR: And what is that?

IS: Well a little bit more attention. But it doesn't require it, you get it by what you're doing. I don't have to try to get the audience. And even if it's only a small group, I get them. I get them you know. And Karl too. Karl definitely. He plays vibraphone and piano and he conducts a 30 piece orchestra free improvisation.

MR: Yes. I was going to bring that up because I saw one on YouTube. And wow, some of the sounds that are created, the textures and all, as they shift. I can imagine being in that audience and just feeling like you're in there.

IS: Ornette always said, "Express yourself musically. It saves you the psychiatrist."

MR: Say that again please.

IS: "Express yourself musically. It saves you the psychiatrist."

MR: I see. Okay. As a matter of fact I have a little audio here.

[audio interlude]

MR: Before this starts, do you and Karl or the musicians have a plan?

IS: A plan?

MR: Any kind of plan?

IS: Spontaneous.

MR: So you start speaking.

IS: Spontaneous. No plan. I find my lyrics, and I try to find the ones that match the music, that would fit in. Fit in the feeling of the audience, the feeling of the room, the feeling of the music.

MR: I guess that goes back to my question about, I was asking about faking an emotion. Like throughout this piece there's times when you're singing and there's times when you're

not. And I'm wondering in my head what are you waiting for when you're not singing. You're letting other musicians —

IS: I listen.

MR: You're listening.

IS: Yeah. And when it's the right moment I go in. If I can relate to what they're doing I fit in there, I go in. And then the music carries me away. There's no more thinking, no more faking, nothing, no. No. And you know, you've heard of the Creative Music Studio, you'll probably ask Karl these questions. It was a famous school we opened here. The belief — before we even came over and met Ornette — in us was always everybody in this world is musical. Everybody. People repress it, people are interested in other things, but the Sufi message says, and I related to that completely because I always believed it, expression deepest in yourself is music. Everybody has it. That's why cranky people, cranky neighbors, the drumming is too loud, they complain, they call the police. Usually it's something they had repressed that maybe they would have loved to do music themselves you know. It's a very, very psychological thing. The audience would not come if they wouldn't be musical. They come because — so and that makes it so pleasant to work with musicians. We do therapy workshops, music therapy workshops in Europe and a concert afterwards. It's like everybody has a feeling for music. Everybody. Everybody.

MR: But some of them along the way, as you say, either they repress it or they — over the years I've done some work with public school teachers with music programs. And these are not music teachers. And you always get a number of people who say, "Oh when they passed out the rhythm I was hiding under the bed." You know, they almost are proud that they can't find the beat.

IS: It's buried deep, unless they dig it out. There was a beautiful thing at the Creative Music Studio where a student walked out of Dollar Brand's, Abdullah Ibrahim's workshop and cried. A guy. And I said, "What's wrong?" And he said, "I'm not black. I will never be able to be a drummer, a good drummer." So I said, "No, you go right back in." And I walked up to Dollar and I told him what the student had said. That's all I told him. And Dollar Brand said to him, "You have a pulse, you have a heartbeat, you have the same feeling from within that people in Africa, in Brazil, you just grew up with march music and they grew up where music is part of a wedding, music is part of every festivity." In Brazil where we were three times for concerts, the children already drum on the street. Music is on the street. It has to do with your upbringing. And some people can bury it so much, you know, to dig it out they need another lifetime.

MR: Wow. This is sometimes a hard question. Did you and Karl feel like over the years you were doing something that was an important part of jazz history?

IS: Maybe Karl but I never, no. I just do what I do.

MR: You just do what you are doing.

IS: And when people appreciate it I am honored. I love it. I'm happy. It makes my day. Even if it's only one person coming up, but usually it's many. You know some people come up and say, "I felt so shitty" you know, "and now I feel so good."

MR: Yeah, that's a high compliment.

IS: Yeah.

MR: How did your daughters feel about what you —

IS: Savia is a dancer.

MR: What's her name?

IS: Savia. She's a dancer and so definitely she has incredible feeling for rhythm and music.

MR: How is this music, it's obviously a challenge to market it.

IS: Oh absolutely. What we do?

MR: Yes.

IS: Well you can not do anything else. You can only do what comes out of your need, what comes out of your personal expression. You cannot do anything else. I was often thinking that I should write a rock & roll song. You know, so we'd make a little bit of more money or something. Forget it. You have to be like that. In Europe I worked in so many clubs before I met Karl. And I worked in a very famous French club with a German jazz group. We went to a lot of jazz festivals. And there was a guy that came every day because he loved the band, and he always sent up some Schnapps, some liquor, and always had some requests. That day I remember another piece of paper came up with a peppermint Schnapps and it said, "Sugar, could you please sing 'You Ain't Nothing But a Hound Dog'?" My saxophone player says, "What does it say?" I told him and he said, "Okay let's rehearse." I said, "Oh no. I cannot sing that song. I cannot. It's an Elvis Presley song, it's an old Gospel, but I can't sing it, I don't even know the lyrics." And the saxophone player, who was the leader, said, "You have to sing it, we get a lot of money from him." He was a very rich guy, must have been a millionaire. I gave in, we rehearsed in the intermission, and I sang "You Ain't Nothing But a Hound Dog." Another piece of paper came up with another peppermint Schnapps, and it said, "Sugar, you will never have to do it again." I couldn't do it. He wanted to hear it the way he is used to. I can't do that. "Thank you Sugar but you never have to do it —"

MR: I suppose you should have been happy that you didn't do a good job with it because he would have come back and asked you again.

IS: But what I love here is that rock & roll and jazz sometimes, I love that. You know because there's very good rock & roll musicians, can be. And a lot of musicians we work with also work in the rock & roll thing. So I love that. That's totally separated in Europe.

Because the art education is so strict there that the idea of something more commercial weaving into a strict art form, it wouldn't work. No.

MR: Oh. Interesting.

IS: But I like that here.

MR: Have you ever heard Big Mama Thornton's version?

IS: No.

MR: I mean that's — it's much more authentic than Elvis, by a long shot. I mean she was a blues shouter.

IS: She's the one that sang "You Ain't Nothing But a Hound Dog?"

MR: Yes. And then Elvis covered it. You know. Plus it was written by two young white men, so that the way this music finds its way in and out to these people is very interesting.

IS: Yeah. I'm sure she sang it great. Because it's a cool song. It's just that I have no relation to it.

MR: Well is the blues part of your exposure in Germany or France?

IS: No. Not at all. It needed a long time until I sang the blues. I was classically raised you know. But now I was just at a birthday party and there was a singer there and we sang over "Monk Blues" and we scatted like crazy. But I would not go into a lot of blues singing because that's not really my background and other people can do it much better.

MR: Okay. I wanted to put on a piece of music here and see if you can tell me something about it.

IS: It's a blindfold?

MR: Well not really. This is actually — isn't this a piece that you guys did?

[audio interlude]

IS: An old piece?

MR: Yeah. Called "Discipline 100?"

IS: It's been so much years you can hardly remember.

MR: Vibes come in here a little bit.

IS: That must be from the "Jazz Dance" album. We did an album called "Jazz Dance" and we had a rock & roll drummer. Because the company we did it for, that's what they wanted, putting our way of playing music together with some rock & roll. It must be "Jazz Dance."

MR: It sounds very contemporary.

IS: You will have to ask Karl because he might remember better.

MR: Yeah, it was just something that I saw on YouTube.

IS: I will remind you afterwards that you play it again on Karl's.

MR: I will. You know some of the way you talk about music and stuff, it makes me think about Merce Cunningham and how he would sometimes change the music for the dances.

IS: No. We did a concert for him. We did music for him. He danced, we did the music, it was a group with Richard Teitelbaum and there was different musicians. Afterwards he came up to us, shaked our hands and said, "Thank you so much but I was too busy dancing, I couldn't listen to the music." We were like, "Oh my God." I was too busy dancing, I could not listen to the music. So that one, I don't know him well. I have no idea what — you know.

MR: This group that I work with in Utica —

IS: Is he still alive?

MR: No I don't think so. But we were able to bring his company to perform for some teachers.

IS: Because he put — it's on this thing and I don't want to put anybody down.

MR: No, no, no.

IS: He was a great dancer, a great choreographer, but that's just the experience we had.

MR: Yes. And the dancers told me that sometimes he would change — they would be doing the same choreography but he would change the music. So it was almost like you are looking for these — "happy accidents" is not really the right word, but these moments where something gels between the music and the dance. It's not planned.

IS: Yeah. I don't know. We weren't that lucky. I mean we played what we did but you know, we thought we could inspire the dancers, but maybe it was just him because the others — I don't know. You know you do the music, you can not always watch the dancers either.

MR: Were you playing live?

IS: Yeah. I can't remember, it was a big hall in Manhattan.

MR: Yeah. Wow. Yeah, that's a pretty interesting experience right there. What was it that you liked about Chet Baker?

IS: Oh, I adore him. Because he sang like he played. I totally adored him. My father was a professor so whenever we came home early from school, my brother Klaus and me — Klaus played drums in my room and I sang. And we had a Chet Baker record going. And I just loved the softness of his voice. He loved the way he phrased. I loved the songs that he sang, [sings] "Time After Time" [scats]. The warmth of his voice, very relaxed, and the way he phrased. Chet Baker couldn't sit and read one note. Chet Baker couldn't read one note of music. He had such a musicality. He never read music. And then Klaus, my brother, that lives now in Italy on the Island of Elba became a drummer, a European drummer in the European rhythm section of Chet Baker. So he was lucky you know. I only met him once in Manhattan when he was already almost totally gone you know. But he was lucky and he really loved to play with him — a lot in France and in Spain and in Germany. And then he quit with him and I said, "How can you quit with Chet Baker?" And he said, "Well in the intermission I had to go with him to the bathroom to find another place where he can stick the needle." And it was so depressing because he was

such a cool guy you know, that he quit. It was just the way he played. He must have been also, when he wasn't on drugs, a great guy. I heard him say on some weird tape, some announcements to the audience you know, "You'd better listen." You know, talk about listening, very intelligent, very beautiful. But the drugs killed him. And that brought me to music, Chet Baker's singing brought me to music. So I always wanted to be a dancer, and my parents sometimes had the money, sometimes didn't have it. And dance you have to do from morning 9:00 to 5:00 in the evening, or 8:00 in the evening you know, to keep that body flexible. And in this society, in the West, you have to go through the whole ballet training in order to become a modern dancer, hip hop dancer, whatever, jazz dancer. But I wanted something with music and that's —

MR: Yeah. I always feel sorry for dancers too because by the time you're 30, you're like — then you're going to have to become a teacher you know.

IS: Yeah. Now it goes up to 45.

MR: Really?

IS: Because of the health awareness and everything. I met people, you can actually put 15 years off the age they are in.

MR: Is it safe to say you've been influenced more by horn players than singers?

IS: Yeah. Much more by instruments than singers. Much more. And then I heard Billie Holiday and of course I adored her. Billie Holiday. She was already dead but I heard her on the record. And I adored her but I couldn't relate to this thing that there was so much sadness in her, and it became a very one thing trip. You know she wouldn't improvise much, she wouldn't — it was all about just her voice expressing the experiences in her life. And that was too heavy for me. And then Joachim-Ernst Berendt, you know, the Pope of Europe, the Jazz Pope of Europe, said after the big Frankfurt Festival where I had sang and he was in the audience, and he came up to me and said, "It was really beautiful, but unless you live a life like Billie Holiday you're not going to reach that kind of expression in your singing." And that's when I woke up and I said, "What? He wants me to be a prostitute? He wants me to go on drugs? He wants me to do this and this?"

MR: Who was it?

IS: Joachim-Ernst Berendt.

MR: Okay.

IS: The Jazz Pope of Europe.

MR: He was like a broadcaster?

IS: Yeah. He came over here when we did for George Wein the big festival at the Avery Fisher Hall on Lincoln Center. He made all the announcements for the orchestra. There was an orchestra you know. My daughter danced. But when he said that to me I said, no.

It's a misunderstanding. You express the experiences of your life but you don't have to be on drugs.

MR: I'm so glad you said that because I had a professor recently ask my opinion, why was it, especially in the forties and fifties, so many of these well known jazz musicians are connected with the drug scene? And I didn't really have an answer for him. I mean you can say well they work in bars and nightclubs. But there's got to be something more than that.

IS: First of all it started with the whole racial thing. Billie Holiday had to go through the kitchen in the hotel because she was black, and so on and so on. So that started it. Second, if you aren't strong, and you become well known, and you are king on stage, and then you have to go home and pay your phone bill, you have to do the daily grind, and if you aren't strong personally you will go on drugs. We worked with Bob Stewart in that big orchestra in Switzerland. Bob Stewart the tuba player.

MR: Tuba player, yeah.

IS: In Switzerland. And a huge success. The orchestra was a huge success. And then we had to come out for three encores, went back to the dressing room and Bob Stewart said with a very sad voice, "Well I was for a moment king again. Now I'll have to go home and see whether I have enough money to pay my bills." So a lot of musicians could not deal with this. You know it started with the racial thing. It started with very, very little pay, long, long tours. Remember the start of Billie Holiday, she never wanted to go on drugs. Never. And she was supposed to do that radio concert after that long bus drive. The tour where every night in another concert. I don't know whether I should say that but the music business can be very evil. Very evil. They take advantage of the artist. Very evil. So she was tired and she said, "I can't do that concert." The drummer or the bass player came in and said, "I have something for you you're gonna love and you will be well." She said, "Get out. I want to have nothing to do with that." She knew. He came back, and then he came back a third time, and she did. She sang the radio concert. And then if you're not strong enough, you know, you are just in.

MR: I think there's part of our culture that we sometimes feel these kinds of artists ought to suffer and we take some kind of fascination in their life stories that are so difficult. You know, like it seems romantic almost. Charlie Parker burns out at age 36 or whatever. And it's a shame. Yeah. Along those same lines, we talked about the seriousness of Billie Holiday. Is there a place in free jazz, the music you do, for humor and lightheartedness?

IS: I don't know what you mean. Of course.

MR: Well okay. Some of the videos I watched, and some of the music — I had a very sort of jilting experience when I was just getting into John Coltrane, right? And someone said,

"Well you should get 'Ascension,' you should buy the record 'Ascension.'" And then I got to free jazz. Well this music, I couldn't handle it. It sounded chaotic to me.

IS: I never heard it.

MR: Okay well —

IS: I know of it but —

MR: But when you do the thing with the large ensemble and the music is taking shape, it seems serious to me, which isn't a bad thing, but does it ever get to the point where musicians are smiling and —

IS: Oh yeah. Oh absolutely.

MR: Okay.

IS: Oh my God yeah. The same with singing lyrics, oh yeah, absolutely. It's part of the humanity, the humor. And if everything that you do in creative expression comes from your openness, then everything is in there. Always.

MR: When you're doing a couple of days of the Creative Music workshops, do you do activities that sort of might cleanse the palette of all the sounds that everybody has been hearing, and all the interaction. Is there a point —

IS: Meditation.

MR: Meditation.

IS: Oh yeah, it's a big part of it. A big part of it is you go back to being alive, which means breathe. My voice workshop is breathe in, breathe out, inhale, exhale. It's the only way we are in the moment. Stuff comes up in our mind, you see it, you don't get involved, you let it go and you go back to just breathe in, breathe out. Be totally in the moment. And the moment, the second you express yourself creatively and it comes from a total open place, that's the state of enlightenment. That would be the state of enlightenment in Buddhism. Vincent Van Gogh — I went to the museum in Holland. You faint. The energy that comes from his original pictures, the light of the colors, the sunshine he created in the pictures, I mean he was painting in France and so on, you can only do something like that when you have these glimpses of enlightenment. He totally identified with the sunflowers, with the sun. He totally identified. But then he goes back into total neurosis, cuts his ear off, drinks absinthe, which is the worst liquor you can drink. It's anise liquor you know. The French are still drinking it. But that together with the painting in the sun can do you in. It's an enlightened, all these big big masters and big musicians, you know, if they weren't totally on drugs then — if you listen to Chet Baker when he was very young there is a lot of humor and vitality in it you know. Later on it became a little bit more dragging — his voice was a little bit more off tune. But because the music is so powerful, the moment you hit it and you put your expression in, it still doesn't matter whether you are on drugs or not. Charlie Parker — almost everything he played is

so absolutely beautiful. And he was on heroin all day long you know. You still have these glimpses of being totally in the moment and totally identified with the music and with what you do. Oh that's a big thing, together with it comes that we are both studying Buddhism. You know we have a big monastery here. We started studying with Trungpa Rinpoche at Naropa Institute in Boulder, Colorado. And it simply had to do with — we came over here and my father died. And I'm probably one of the more lucky ones. I loved my parents. And my mother said, "Save the airplane ticket, by the time you come back" — and I freaked out. Then there was a book that Karl had bought or brought from the library or something. And so often when you need help I open it up and there was this page that said — I say it in my words — you get confronted to something deal with it. Don't repress it. Deal with it. Cry out. Let go. So it's always be in the moment. It comes back to you, deal with it, let it go, and then time wears it out and it will get weaker and weaker and fade out and fade out. And it helped me tremendously. And that brought me to Buddhism, you know. Because I've never been in any other religion than we deeply believing in Jesus Christ you know. But that part of it is the one that — Trungpa Rinpoche, that whole Naropa Institute, was full of poets, dancers and musicians. Alan Ginsberg, William Burrows, I mean all these people were there. And Dave Holland. I mean we all went out there. Lots of jazz musicians.

MR: This was in Colorado?

IS: Colorado. Boulder.

MR: Boulder okay.

IS: Called the Naropa Institute. It's a Buddhist university.

MR: Along those same lines, you know on my drive down here I listened to the news on NPR a couple of times. And there is so much serious turmoil in the world, it just seems, well I can't even describe how it seems. But is your creative process affected by what's going on around you? Even locally or world wide?

IS: Well it puts you more into music. The worse one side gets, the economy and politics and so on, government, the more musicians jump up. Because the more the need is there for creative expression. So the worse it gets the more we need to do music you know. In terms of effecting us, what's happening in Iraq and Russia and so on, I don't know. I wouldn't know whether we would express that in the music. Probably unconsciously it would be woven in also. It's not consciously otherwise it would be totally negative, no.

MR: I know there's been a few instances of critics describing some of the free players, Archie Shepp and so forth, as sounding very angry.

IS: Some of the free players.

MR: Yes.

IS: Oh yeah.

MR: Do you think they were angry most of the time? I don't know if that's a fair question or not.

IS: It's all an ego thing. It's all an ego thing. Yeah. It has to do with lifestyle, it has to do with no money, it has to do with the way the musicians are treated. And if you don't work on it you become really angry you know. The music business is horrible. It's demonic.

MR: Demonic.

IS: Demonic. When Whitney Houston died, Whitney Houston? I totally adored her. She was, for me, the purist Gospel singer. Total purity. I cried almost every time I heard her. When she died the African singer, what's her name, went on CNN and she said, "The music business is demonic."

MR: I know who you're talking about but I can't think of her name.

IS: Yeah I can't remember her name. And once they have you, they discover your talent, they have you. They get you. It's like I picked up a journal, a newspaper in a coffee shop in Europe, and they were writing about Jimi Hendrix. The advantage the managers, the producers, made off Jimi Hendrix is unbelievable. At the end, where he really made a lot of money, they only gave him a stipend for a week. Sometimes because he needed acid, to buy acid, he slept in a park instead of in a hotel. So it's — and he was a very good hearted person. Very, very good hearted. And if you don't work on it, you are angry. I don't know how we do it. All our lives we make only money on music. Only. Only money on music. We only make a living on music.

MR: I was going to ask that. You know you have it in common with a lot of jazz musicians.

IS: And you have to work not to become angry.

MR: What was the toughest decade for you, or the toughest years?

IS: When we started the Creative Music Studio, when we came here. We started the school, we had a daughter and we didn't want to be in the city, so the child could grow up in the country. And we had absolutely no money. And the bank borrowed us — lent us $500 and we bought a rug and we started in our house that we had rented. It was tough when we started the school. And then, still on and off — we still owe $2,000 for a heating bill here.

MR: Some things never change. Wow. Just to wrap up, I've really enjoyed this conversation. When you write a poem or a song, at what point do you think of the title? And are titles important?

IS: Yes, sometimes the title is first. I wrote a song, "Africa." It's my only poem that actually won an award by the Washington Poet's Gallery. They had asked me for a poem and I sent them "Africa." And then some — no usually I have the plan, what I'm going to do, and that's the title. Like "Four Seasons" — spring, summer, winter fall — that's on my last CD, and so on and so on.

MR: I wanted to play something for you and get a quick thought on it, if I can find it here.

IS: Is it us again?

MR: No. I'll bet you'll recognize it.

[audio interlude — Babatunde]

IS: We worked a lot with him.

MR: You got to perform with him. Didn't you get to perform with him?

IS: Oh yeah. We went to Africa with him. A creative opportunity. We did a four week tour to Africa. It was wonderful. I sang African songs in the African language with him.

MR: That's great.

IS: Yeah. Babatunde.

MR: Well I've enjoyed our conversation.

IS: I enjoyed it too.

MR: And you made some things clearer for me. I'm a person whose musical tastes run to Cannonball Adderley in the sixties. Soul jazz you know. So some of the ways you spoke about your music I found very —

IS: He was the heavy one, right? There were two brothers.

MR: Yes, brother Nat and Cannonball.

IS: Nat? What did he play?

MR: Nat played the cornet. And he was quite the composer. Well good luck with your upcoming recording project of the standards and all that.

IS: Thank you. And I'll get you the CD.